Music practice packet

DRAFTING · ARTIST INTERVIEW · 2021

Black Thought

In a 2021 interview, Black Thought described writing on a computer and in phone notes. He also found old notebooks containing drafts. In the same interview, he recalled leaving Millersville University and returning to Philadelphia.

The Paris Review · April 29, 2021 (https://www.theparisreview.org/blog/2021/04/29/everything-writes-itself-an-interview-with-black-thought/)

FEEDBACK · ARTIST INTERVIEW · 2014

Rapsody

Rapsody recalled that producer 9th Wonder heard her CD in late 2005. He told her it was a good start and that there were things to work on. She also described learning how much cadence and melody mattered.

Sonicbids · January 8, 2014 (https://blog.sonicbids.com/rapsody-interview)

PLANNING · ORIGINAL INTERVIEW · 2020

Megan Thee Stallion

In a 2020 PEOPLE interview, Megan was taking part-time online health-administration courses at Texas Southern University. She described fitting schoolwork around shows.

PEOPLE · June 28, 2020 (https://people.com/music/megan-thee-stallion-pursue-degree-make-late-mom-proud/)

CURIOSITY · FIRST-PERSON ARTICLE · 2015

GZA

In a 2015 article published under his name, GZA described science as a long-standing interest and a way to understand his surroundings. He connected that curiosity with subjects he wrote about.

Cuepoint / Medium · May 27, 2015 (https://medium.com/cuepoint/gza-speaks-the-lost-art-of-lyricism-ee84510e7268)

PRODUCTION & COLLABORATION · FIRST-PERSON ACCOUNT · 2013

Erykah Badu / J Dilla

In her 2013 account, Erykah Badu recalled choosing a record and a passage from it. She said producer J Dilla taught her how to sample that passage.

Red Bull Music Academy Daily · February 21, 2013 (https://daily.redbullmusicacademy.com/2013/02/when-erykah-met-dilla/)

RETURNING TO A DRAFT · ARTIST INTERVIEW · 2025

Little Simz

In a 2025 Song Exploder interview, Little Simz said she wrote a poem in spring 2022 and returned to it two years later while making “Free.”

Song Exploder · episode 294 · 2025; official transcript available (https://songexploder.net/little-simz)

VOCABULARY & SOUND · ARTIST INTERVIEW · 2010

Eminem

In 2010, Eminem discussed dictionary reading for vocabulary and demonstrated rhyming through pronunciation in his interview with Anderson Cooper.

CBS / 60 Minutes · first published October 10, 2010; updated 2011 (https://www.cbsnews.com/news/eminems-incredible-rise-to-stardom-07-08-2011/)

RHYTHM & LISTENING · ARTIST INTERVIEW · 2020

Rakim

In a 2020 interview, Rakim recalled learning instruments as a child and studying jazz timing with his brother at a community center. He described using John Coltrane’s saxophone phrasing as an influence on his rap delivery.

The Believer · John O’Connor · April 1, 2020 (https://www.thebeliever.net/an-interview-with-rakim/)

PEER LEARNING & TECHNIQUE · ARTIST INTERVIEW · 2025

Lupe Fiasco

In a 2025 Johns Hopkins interview, Lupe Fiasco recalled sharing verses and getting feedback from other rappers at high school. He also described teaching rap techniques and introducing experienced rappers to linguistics and communication theory through the Society of Spoken Art.

Johns Hopkins University / The Hub · Aleyna Rentz · January 7, 2025 (https://hub.jhu.edu/2025/01/07/lupe-fiasco-joins-peabody-faculty/)

MUSIC LEARNING & REHEARSAL · ARTIST INTERVIEW · 2023

Doechii

After her 2023 Coachella debut, Doechii told UPROXX that performing-arts high school included chorus, writing music and music theory. She also described rehearsing with her band and dancers every day for two weeks before the show.

UPROXX · Cherise Johnson · April 20, 2023 (https://uproxx.com/music/doechii-interview-coachella-2023/)

01 / WRITING & REVISION · ABOUT 5–7 MINUTES

Four lines. Two versions.

Make a listener picture an invented scene. Write, speak quietly, or think it through.

Original teaching example · fictional scene

The last bus pulled away.
I stood under the shelter.
The rain was loud.
I waited for a ride.

1. **Start your own scene.** Use four lines about an ordinary object or fictional moment. You can also work from the example.
2. **Keep the first version.** On paper, in your own notes, or in memory.
3. **Change one thing.** Replace a vague detail, move a pause, or cut a word that does not help.
4. **Compare.** What changed in the picture, meaning or sound?

See one possible revision

The last bus pulled away.
I folded my ticket twice.
Rain rattled the shelter roof.
I watched for familiar headlights.

This version adds visible and audible details.

If you want feedback

Ask a willing listener what they remember and where they lose the idea.

What is left from a $500 show?

Invented scenario. Two collaborators receive a $500 fee. Travel costs $75 and an engineer costs $125. They agree to keep $100 for a future project and split the rest equally.

1. Subtract the two expenses. How much cash remains?
2. Set aside the agreed reserve. How much is available to split?
3. Divide that amount between the two people.
4. What needs to be agreed before the show? What cost might be missing?

Compare with the worked example

Fee received	$500
Travel + engineer	−$200
Cash after those expenses	$300
Agreed project reserve	−$100
Available to distribute	$200
Each person's share	$100

The reserve is cash kept for later, not automatically another expense. This does not calculate taxable profit or final after-tax income. Ask who approves costs, when payment happens and what happens if a cost changes.

03 / DELIVERY & MEANING · ABOUT 3–5 MINUTES

Same words. Different emphasis.

Change what a listener notices without changing the words. Speak privately, mark the sentence on paper, or think through the meanings.

Original teaching sentence

We can start the track tomorrow.

1. Put the emphasis on **we**. What might that suggest about who will start?
2. Move it to **start**, then **tomorrow**. What changes?
3. Try a pause after "track." Mark it with a slash if you prefer. Does that create a different expectation?
4. Choose an emphasis for an original line of your own. What do you want a listener to notice?

Compare three possible readings

WE might contrast this group with somebody else. **START** might distinguish beginning from finishing. **TOMORROW** might contrast tomorrow with today. Context can change the reading.

In her January 8, 2014 Sonicbids interview (https://blog.sonicbids.com/rapsody-interview), Rapsody discussed cadence and melody. Rapsody's process story.

A reference that earns its place.

Source A · NASA

Our paraphrase: The Moon reflects a small part of the sunlight that reaches it.

Moonlight (https://science.nasa.gov/moon/moonlight/) · NASA Science · updated February 12, 2026 · explanation of reflected light.

Source B · ESA

Our paraphrase: ESA compares planets reflecting starlight with our Moon reflecting sunlight.

What do exoplanets look like? (https://www.esa.int/Science_Exploration/Space_Science/Exoplanets/What_do_exoplanets_look_like) · European Space Agency · "Clouds and surface" section · no publication date displayed; checked October 2, 2026.

1. **State the narrow fact.** What do both cards support? What would go beyond them?
2. **Check where it came from.** These are explanations from two agencies. Neither page attributes this explanation to the other. They are not two new experiments. Two headlines repeating one interview would still be one origin.
3. **Make two original lines.** Use the idea and keep a source note. Rhyme is optional. A metaphor can be imagined; a factual claim needs support.
4. **Ask if it belongs.** Does the detail help your scene or meaning, or is it there only to sound impressive?

Compare with one original example

The Moon sends borrowed sunlight down.
I carry yesterday's idea through town.

The first line uses reflected sunlight; "borrowed" is a metaphor. The second line is imagined.

GZA's 2015 account.

Same moment. Two viewpoints.

Invented rehearsal scene

Alex thinks rehearsal begins at four. Jordan thinks it begins at five. They are reading different versions of a message. Neither has checked which version is current.

1. Write, speak privately or imagine two lines from Alex's view. What does Alex know? What is still an assumption?
2. Try two lines from Jordan's view. Let the difference come from information, not a stereotype about either person.
3. Choose what a listener should understand that the characters do not yet know.
4. Write one useful question the collaborators could ask to check the plan.

Compare one possible pair

Alex: “The saved note says four; I’m ready by the door.”

Jordan: “My screen says five; I think I’m right on time.”

These original fictional lines show why each person might believe the schedule. A useful question is: “Which message is the latest, and can we confirm the time together?”

Choose a part. Move it around.

Write, speak privately, quietly tap, or imagine the arrangement.

Four original teaching phrases

Doors open.
Lights low.
Ready now.
Take a breath.

1. **Make four parts.** Invent four short phrases, patterns or descriptions of sounds. You can use our phrases instead.
2. **Choose one part.** What do you want someone to notice? Repeat that part once.
3. **Change the placement.** Try the repeat earlier or later, or put a pause before it. Keep two versions on paper, in your notes or in memory.
4. **Explain the difference.** What changes in the meaning, pattern or feeling? Choose a version, combine them, or decide the repeat does not help.

Compare two possible arrangements

Version A: Doors open. Lights low. Ready now. Ready now. Take a breath.

Version B: Doors open. Lights low. Ready now. Take a breath. [pause] Ready now.

A could make readiness feel insistent. B could make the last phrase feel like a decision after a breath.

For feedback, ask a willing person what they notice and invite one alternative.

Badu’s account of a lesson with J Dilla

One word. More choices.

Write, speak quietly or think through the word choices.

Original teaching example · invented sentences

Word: light
Meaning choices: brightness; not heavy
Sound family: night, bright, out of sight

The room filled with light.

I kept my bag light.

1. **Choose one word.** Try “light,” “break” or a word from your own idea. Use a dictionary if you want another meaning.
2. **Follow the meaning.** Explain what your word means in this line. Could a listener understand it another way?
3. **Follow the sound.** Find two words or a short phrase that repeat a sound you like. You can speak them, imagine them or mark the sounds on paper.
4. **Make and compare.** Write or imagine two original lines. Change one word or phrase. Which meaning or sound helps your idea?

One way to compare choices

In the example, “light” changes meaning between the two sentences. “Bright” shares a sound with “light,” but replacing one with the other could change the grammar and meaning.

Eminem: vocabulary · Lupe Fiasco: peer learning

Your week

1 · Pick a small target

Music: Choose clearer imagery, delivery, a reference or understanding a budget.

Learning: Pick one question about an assignment, skill, credit or learning option. Name someone who could help.

2 · Collect a detail

Music: Notice three details about an ordinary object or invented place.

Learning: Read, listen to or discuss a short passage. Keep one question for a teacher or librarian.

3 · Check a reference

Music: Try two lines with a checked fact, or use the provided Moon example.

Learning: Identify what a source supports. Ask for source help if you need it.

4 · Keep two versions

Music: Try a second version of four lines.

Learning: Apply one revision to an assignment you choose, or ask a tutor to compare two versions with you.

5 · Explain the money

Music: Explain the split in the invented $500 show.

Learning: Practice the subtraction/division, or ask a math teacher or tutor where the calculation gets confusing.

6 · Try a step if it fits

Music: Read, speak privately or silently review a short piece, or compare two arrangements.

Learning: If useful, try one action: practice a music skill independently, use a library resource, ask a collaborator or tutor for help, begin an assignment, or ask a counselor about credits/options.

7 · Keep what helped

Music: Compare what changed and what you want to keep.

Learning: Name one helpful thing and one difficulty. Choose a realistic next action, change the plan, or choose none.

Make the support request concrete

“Could you help me with _____? I can try _____ at _____. The part that might get in the way is _____.”

If you are not enrolled, ask an education worker about locally appropriate options and eligibility. Safety, transport, work, money and learning access may need practical support beyond an activity.

What would help right now?

Get better at writing

> **“Can you look at these two versions and tell me where the idea gets clearer?”**

Try a teacher, tutor, librarian or a trusted person in an established arts program.

Check a fact or reference

> **“Does this source support what I wrote, and where could I check it?”**

Try a librarian or subject teacher. Use the provided offline source cards if browsing is not available.

Explain a creative choice

> **“This is what I want someone to notice. What changes between these versions?”**

Try a music or drama teacher, mentor or willing listener in an established arts program.

Catch up or check my credits

Ask a school counselor or education support worker about one missing assignment, credit or enrollment question.

> **“What is one realistic step, and who can help me take it?”**

If you are not enrolled, ask about locally approved options and eligibility.

Understand music business

> **“What will I actually receive, what work is expected, and who controls the recording?”**

For real agreements, involve a trusted adult and qualified advice. Do not share a contract or personal information with strangers online.

School is not working for me

Safety, transport, learning support, work and missing credits need practical help.

> **“This is the part I need help with. What can we change first?”**

Choose a reliable counselor, teacher, caregiver, youth advocate or education worker you already know or can meet through a trusted organization.

I need money now

Ask a trusted adult or youth-program staff member about age-appropriate work and immediate support, alongside education options.

This site cannot provide a job, case management or financial support.

For adults

A flexible 20–25 minute session for ages 13–18, individually or in a small group.

Before the session

Read a story, try an activity and check the source note. Bring paper and pencils, or open the offline packet. Offer reading aloud, silent reflection and spoken responses. Do not infer reading level from age. Let the participant select a skill without choosing an artist.

Explain your setting's actual confidentiality limits.

1. **Invite · 2 minutes.** "Would you like to try something connected to writing or music?" Declining is fine.
2. **Choose · 3 minutes.** Let them select a story or go directly to an activity. Ask what the artist actually practiced. Then ask what the participant wants to make or understand; allow no connection.
3. **Try · 5–7 minutes.** Use a fictional scene or the invented budget. No public performance; keep creative work private.
4. **Reflect · 5 minutes.** "What changed? What did not help? Did this add pressure or make the goal feel harder?" Discuss the intended meaning, not whether their dialect is correct.
5. **Connect · 5 minutes.** "Could a class, library, program or person help with this?" Accept that a connection may feel forced.
6. **Close · 2 minutes.** Offer a voluntary next action and a reliable support route. Name who can help and how contact would happen.

If someone disagrees

"My favorite rapper dropped out." Artists' paths vary. Black Thought's story here includes leaving college. That does not explain what caused success or choose a path for you.

"I do not need college to make music." A college credential is not a universal requirement. What learning and support fit your goal?

"I am already good with words." Start with that strength. Which part would you like more control over?

"School has not helped me." What has been missing or unhelpful? A practical response may matter more than another activity.

"I need money now." Let's find a person who can help with immediate options and a plan that fits.

"You want me to give up music." You choose the music goal. This resource offers practice, learning choices and help.

Safeguarding and evaluation

No improvement in attendance, graduation or justice outcomes has been established for this resource.

Before a pilot with minors, a qualified partner must establish appropriate permission, assent/consent, safeguarding, review, accessibility and data handling. Do not recruit or record minors without those safeguards. Participation must not affect grades, privileges, legal treatment or services. Never request charges, case histories, trauma or autobiographical lyrics.